

Chrysler Building

The Art Deco masterpiece that stylishly adorns the New York skyline and the first man-made structure to be taller than 1,000 ft (300 m)



In a city famed for its skyscrapers, the Chrysler Building on the East Side of Manhattan in New York City is the most renowned of them all. Whereas most tall buildings are faceless, solid slabs, the Chrysler Building is an Art Deco masterpiece of high style and subtle design, its top a metallic crown that lights up the skyline.

Although the building was the headquarters of the Chrysler Corporation of carmakers, the company did not own the building. It was built by Walter Chrysler (1875–1940), the company's founder, and served as the corporation's headquarters from 1930 until the mid-1950s. Walter liked the building so much that he decided to pay for it and own it himself so that his children could inherit it.

Designed by William Van Alen, at 1,046 ft (318.9 m) high, it aimed to be the tallest building in the world. During construction, it overtook its nearest rival—40 Wall Street—and when it opened on May 27, 1930, it claimed that towering prize.



◁ SECRET SPIRE

The Chrysler Building's architect secretly built a spire 125 ft (38 m) long and hoisted it on top of the tower, making it 1,173 3/4 ft (359 m) taller than 40 Wall Street.

△ ART DECO STYLE

The gargoyles on the 31st floor are designed to look like a car's mascot, and replicas of Chrysler cars' hubcaps and fenders adorn the walls.

TALLER AND TALLER

When the Chrysler Building opened in May 1930, it was the world's tallest building. On May 1, 1931, though, it lost the crown to the Empire State Building, and it has twice been overtaken in New York since then by the two World Trade Center buildings.

